



Regional Analysis

RRHS APHG
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What is a Region?

- A **region** is the basic unit of geography.
- area of land that has common features.
- can be defined by natural or human features,
- An area or division, especially part of a country or the world having definable characteristics but not always fixed boundaries.



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Just as historians break history into Eras for study, geographers break the surface of the earth into regions. It is a way to make sense of the larger world by “zooming in” on certain characteristics.

Unifying Characteristics

- Regions of North America as described Joel Garreau of *The Washington Post* in his book *The Nine Nations of North America* (1981)



Regions divide the earth's surface by looking at unifying characteristics – all the places included in that region will share the characteristic (with some level of generalization, of course), and places outside that region will be different. The more “zoomed out” you are, the more generalization will need to be assumed.

Characteristics may be cultural (language, religion, ethnicity, etc.), political (government territory/subdivisions, international organizations), economic (trade ties), or physical (climate, topographic, etc.), or any combination thereof.

For Example: “North America” is a world region of mostly Protestant (non-Roman Catholic) Christian and English speaking people. However, if you “zoom in”, there are different branches of Christianity and more languages being spoken that would allow for sub-regions to be formed within the larger “North American” region. In particular, in the Canadian province of Quebec the majority of people speak French, not English, and they are Catholic Christians. The rest of the majority of the US and Canada speak English and are Protestant Christians, so Quebec would form a distinctive sub-region.

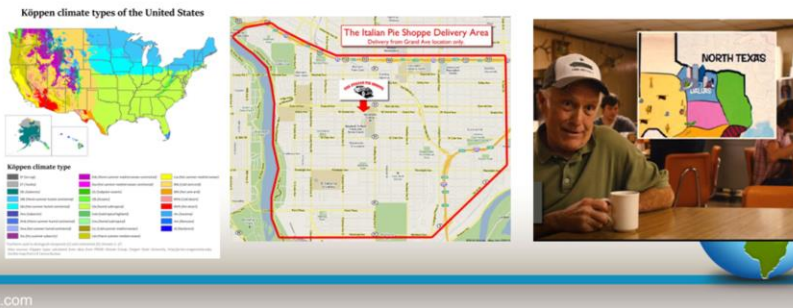
On the map above (right), the regions were created based on characteristics common to that place – while the names of the regions may be considered archaic or even

offensive to some, they are representative of an earlier generation in American culture.

“The Foundry” represents the historic “heart” of the United States – the central core of the country’s earliest years, where it was founded. The “Empty Quarter” is the area of the Great Plains and Prairies, stretching into the Arctic tundra that is very sparsely populated. The southern portion of the U.S. has a significant overlap with Mexico’s history (more detail on that region later...). The breadbasket is the wheat/corn/soybean (cereal grains) growing region of the U.S. Dixie, more commonly referred to today as the American South, is united by a shared agrarian (farming) heritage, the Confederate States of America, and a pronounced accent known as the “southern draw”. Notice that Texas has overlap with all three.

Three Types of Regions

- Formal – common quantifiable traits/political units
- Functional – spatial interaction
- Perceptual – individual identity/experiences



Regions can be classified as one of three types, depending on their purpose: Formal, functional, or perceptual.

Formal regions: based on quantifiable data (measurements such as rainfall totals, elevation, census data, etc.) of a shared trait OR they are political units with defined boundaries.

Functional regions: based on spatial interaction between a node/hub and the surrounding area – there are flows of people, goods, or ideas within this type of region.

Perceptual regions: based on the individual's unique experiences and understanding of the area – their perceptions.

Formal Regions

- Quantifiable unifying characteristic
- Political Units

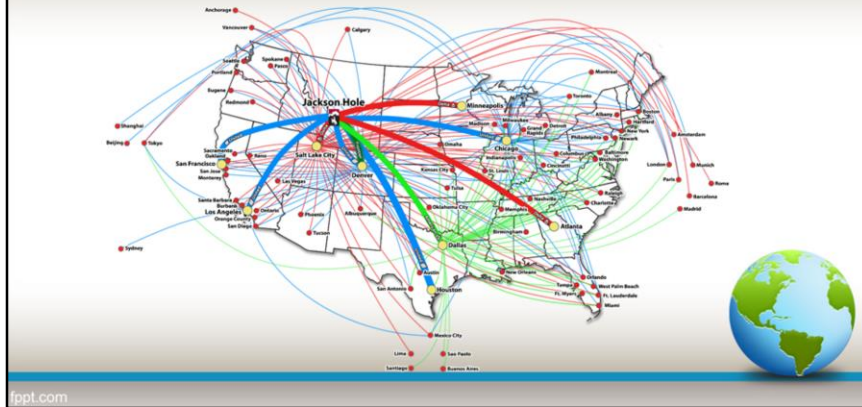


Formal regions are based on quantifiable information. The area within the region will share the unifying characteristics (that being observed to create the region), and the areas outside of that region will have different characteristics.

Boundaries for formal regions are based on where the majority of the unifying characteristic exists – for example, the majority of people in the North American region speak English, while the majority of people in Latin America speak a Romance language.

Functional Regions

- Based on movement/flows/spatial interactions



Functional regions are based on spatial interaction between a node/hub and the surrounding area. There are FLOWS involved of people, goods, or ideas (including radio signals/cell phone signals, etc.).

A school attendance zone is a good example of a functional region. The school is the “node”, and all the addresses which fall inside the functional region will send their kids to that school.

Zip codes are also functional regions – they designate which post office will deliver your mail to your house.

The map above shows the functional region of the Jackson Hole, Wyoming, airport (the places to which you can fly from Jackson Hole, including indirect flights).

Sometimes referred to as **nodal regions**

Other functional regions include restaurant delivery areas, the area that receives the signal for local radio stations, and metropolitan areas.

Metropolitan areas are census-designated places that are defined by commuter zones and urban centrality – the people who live in the surrounding communities often travel into the larger city for work, entertainment, or shopping. For example, the Austin Metropolitan Area – Austin is the larger city, and a large percentage of people who live in Pflugerville, Round Rock, Cedar Park, Leander, Westlake, Lake Travis, Buda, Kyle, Del Valley, Bastrop, and Elgin commute into the city for work.

Perceptual Regions

- Individual
- Shaped by experiences

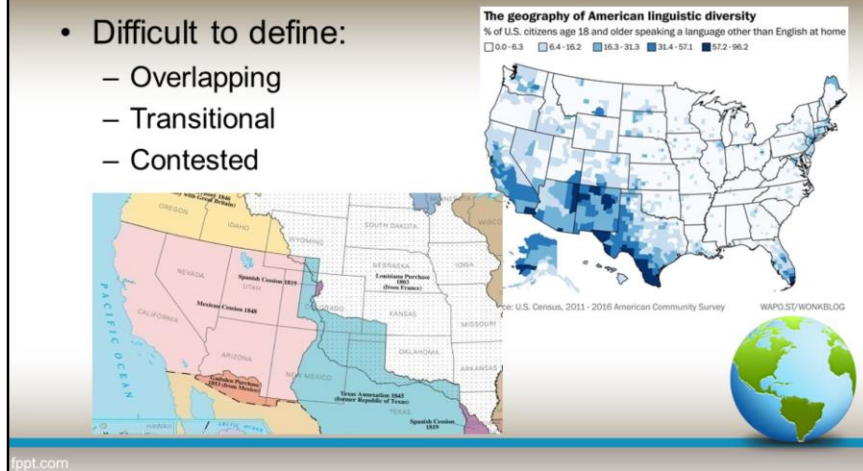


Perceptual regions exist in your head. This information is not quantifiable, it is qualitative. Your personal travels, education, media exposure, and opinions determine your own formation of perceptual regions. They are unique to each person.

Sometimes called **vernacular regions**

Trouble with Regional Boundaries

- Difficult to define:
 - Overlapping
 - Transitional
 - Contested



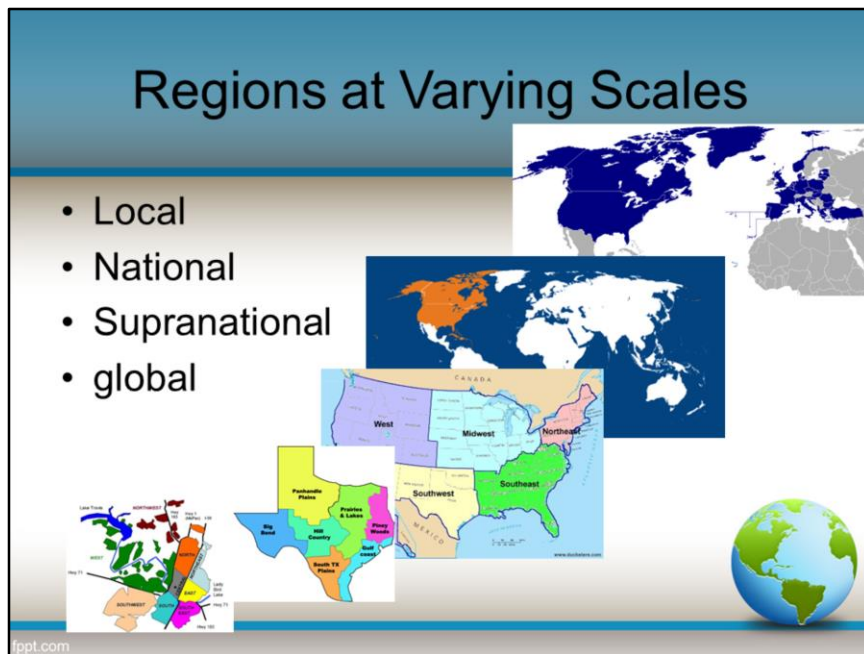
Boundaries (the edges) are not hard-set, and sometimes there is significant overlap in the transitions between regions.

Overlapping Regions: Regions may be referred to as different names (i.e., The Middle East instead of Southwest Asia) that are more political or Eurocentric due to our own political and cultural histories. Pay particular attention to the unifying characteristics that are used to classify the region, as the places included will change – i.e., North Africa and Southwest Asia are similar historically and culturally and a common major region used to make comparisons, but when the common characteristic is “The Islamic World”, the region grows significantly to include central Asia, most of South Asia, and Indonesia. Likewise, the boundaries of North America (the continent) and North America (the Region) do not coincide due to cultural and historical factors. The Russian Domain often includes former soviet states that are now independent, but are still heavily tied politically, culturally, and economically to Russia. There are significant cultural, economic, and political differences between the countries of Western Europe and those of Eastern Europe, just as there is a significant variety of culture and economics within the United States.

Transitional – where do you draw the line between English speakers and Spanish

speakers in the U.S.? Most of the time, the political border between the two countries is used as the official boundary, but there are significant numbers of Spanish speakers on the U.S. side. While the map shown above includes all languages spoken at home other than English, there is a clear pattern of linguistic diversity along the U.S.'s southern border. Should those counties be included with Latin America, given the history of those places? Texas, New Mexico, Arizona, and California were all part of Mexico at one time (Texas until its independence in 1836, and the rest until the Treaty of Guadalupe Hidalgo (1848) and the Gadsden Purchase (1853) that ended the Mexican-American war in which Mexico ceded the territories to the United States, and the United States agreed that Spanish would be treated as an equal language for the Spanish-speaking residents already occupying that territory).

Contested – Speaking of the Mexican American War (1846-1848), that war started over a contested boundary after The Republic of Texas was annexed by the United States. The region between the Rio Grande River and the Neches Rivers was claimed by both countries, and Mexico did not recognize Texas's independence of over a decade. Not all contested regions end in war – though political conflicts do often involve territorial claims and access to resources. Another example is the East China Sea/Sea of Japan – who gets to name the region? We will discuss such conflicts in more detail in our culture unit.



Just like scale of analysis, regions come in varying scales. We will have much more specific criteria to determine a region that's really "zoomed in" compared to one clumps together a large portion of the earth.

Supranational Regions are economic, military, or political organizations comprised of multiple countries, such as the European Union or ASEAN (Association of South East Asian Nations)

The maps above from upper right (most zoomed out) to bottom left:

NATO members (supranational organization includes both European countries and North America)

North American region

Regions of the United States

Regions of Texas

Regions of Austin

S.P.E.E.D.

- S = Social
- P = Political
- E = Economic
- E = Environmental
- D = Demographic



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Descriptive characteristics

“Development”

- Relative (comparative) term
 - More Developed (MDC)
 - Less Developed (LDC)
 - Newly Industrialized (NIC)



“Development” is a relative term that describes a country/region’s economic development, standard of living, and human development.

Wealthier countries with robust economies are described as “more developed”

Not as wealthy, but up-and-coming countries are described as “Newly Industrialized”

Poorer, often resource-poor or economically disadvantaged countries are described as “less developed”

SPEED Characteristics of MDCs

S = higher levels of education, better access to healthcare

P = stable governments, mixed economic systems

E = highly diversified economies, majority work in services, large middle class

E = environmental regulations in place

D = few children per family, long life expectancy, slow to no population growth



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While these characteristics vary among More Developed Countries, these descriptors offer a broad overview of the shared traits of more developed countries

Socially, MDCs have higher levels of education and equality of education for both boys and girls (both are likely to finish high school and continue on to college or trade school). Literacy rates (the % of people who can read and write a simple paragraph related to their occupation at age 15) are approaching or at 100%. Additionally, MDCs have a high level of access to healthcare.

Politically, MDCs tend to stable, participatory governments (such as a Federal Republic or a parliamentary system) with elected officials (though some may still have a monarchy as figurehead, they typically serve as Diplomats for foreign and public relations and do not have control over the government). Women have equal rights to participate in the government (voting, participation, etc.), and suffrage is universal (all adults over a certain age are legally allowed to vote)

Economically, MDCs have more advanced economies – they are diversified, run on technology (both of the digital and machinery varieties), factory goods are mass-produced with lots of machinery, farming is commercial and utilizes advanced

technology. A large percentage of the citizens (70ish%+) work in **service jobs/tertiary economic activities** (teaching, doctors, retail, hospitality, customer service, etc.). Due to mechanization, fewer people work in **manufacturing/secondary economic activities** (about 20%), but manufacturing output is high due. Finally, very few people work in **(primary economic activities: extraction of natural resources) growing food or harvesting resources** (1-2%). This is also due to mechanization. With advanced technology, this small percentage of the population is able to feed not only their own fellow citizens, but often are leading exporters of foods and resources.

Environmentally, MDCs consume the vast majority of the world's resources. For example, the U.S. has 5% of the world's population, but consumes 25% of the world's resources. Due to this consumption, they are often the leading carbon emitters in the world. However, MDCs have also made the shift toward environmental protections – air quality has improved, sanitation services (trash and water treatment) are nearly universal (available to everyone), and businesses must abide by environmental protections (regulations) or they risk being fined. Some MDCs have stronger enforcement of these regulations than others.

*Demographics are statistics about the population

Demographically, MDCs have longer life expectancies (see access to healthcare under “S” above), fewer babies per family, and slower population growth – we will spend a good portion of Unit 2 learning about demographics.

SPEED characteristics of LDCs

S = low levels of education, low access to healthcare

P = more likely to have government instability/corruption, gender inequality

E = agrarian (farming)/resource harvesting dependent economies

E = few environmental regulations in place

D = many children per family, shorter life expectancy, rapid population growth



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While these characteristics vary among More Developed Countries, these descriptors offer a broad overview of the shared traits of more developed countries

Socially, LDCs have lower levels of education and gender inequality in education. Boys are more likely to finish high school, while girls often must leave school when they reach puberty or must leave to assist with farming duties and/or caring for siblings. Literacy rates are significantly lower than in LDCs, and there is a large gap between the literacy rates of men and women. Additionally, LDCs tend to have less access to quality medical care.

Politically, while it is not true of all LDCs, there is a higher likelihood of government instability or corruption in LDCs – the government may lack the means or ability to meet the needs of the population. Women have less access to participating in government and fewer rights than in MDCs, so they may not be allowed to vote or hold office.

Economically, LDCs have less developed economies – they are overly dependent on agriculture or resource harvesting, and generally lack the diversity (and therefore stability) of more advanced economies. A large percentage of the citizens (70ish%+)

work in farming – these farmers are often subsistence farmers (farm just enough to feed their own family) and do not have a true income, therefore, their economic contribution is low to the overall economy. There is much less access to machinery to the average citizen in LDCs – this includes machinery we often take for granted such as tractors and cars. The average working farmer grows their food the old fashioned way. These countries are especially vulnerable to droughts as crop failures result in famine. Commercial farms are often owned and run by foreign corporations (i.e., Dole Banana) and local farmers are at risk to being pushed off their land. A small percentage people in urban areas work in manufacturing, and the rest work in services (government, teachers, etc.). There is a large gap between the wealthy and the poor, as the middle class is very small.

Environmentally, LDCs tend to produce less carbon emissions due to a lack of manufacturing or access to machinery. However, there are also very few environmental regulations in place and the commercial farming and manufacturing that does take place often does so with impunity to the damage they leave behind (i.e., water pollution from pesticide runoff, soil degradation, deforestation, low air quality in large cities due to factory pollution, etc.

Demographically, LDCs have shorter life expectancies (see access to healthcare under “S” above), many more babies per family (higher infant death rates and lack of access to birth control), and rapid population growth – many more babies are being born and surviving than ever before, but families are still dependent on many children to care for the parents in their old age and to help the family economically.

SPEED characteristics of NICs

S = improving levels of education, more access to healthcare, especially in urban areas

P = greater gender equality

E = manufacturing-based economies

E = limited environmental protections in place

D = family sizes are getting smaller, life expectancy is increasing, population is growing but at a slower rate.



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Socially, there has been great progress made within the past couple generations for literacy rates. People who live in urban areas often have greater access to healthcare, good infrastructure including sanitation, and greater gender equality in education. Rural areas may lag in these areas. The middle class is growing, but there is still a high rate of poverty, particularly in the urban slums that develop around the rapidly growing cities.

Politically, greater equality for women is being achieved – women may be able to own property, hold public office, and vote.

Economically, the country's GNI (gross national income) per capita is increasing. The middle class is growing, and there has been a shift toward manufacturing (**secondary economic activities**) and service jobs (**tertiary economic activities**). About 10-15% of the country is still employed in agriculture (**primary economic activities**), a large percent in manufacturing (~40% or more, especially in labor demanding manufacturing, such as textiles), and the rest in services.

Environmentally, cities are starting to get sanitation infrastructure, but NICs commonly face issues of industrial pollution, soil degradation from demanding

commercial farming practices, water pollution, poor air quality, and smog.

Demographically, there is a demographic shift from large families to small families between LDCs and MDCs. NICs are in the middle of that shift, so the population is still growing, but the rate is slowing down.

Major World Regions



You will remember the major world regions as defined by college board from your Regions quiz.

On the slides that follow are examples of other major world regions

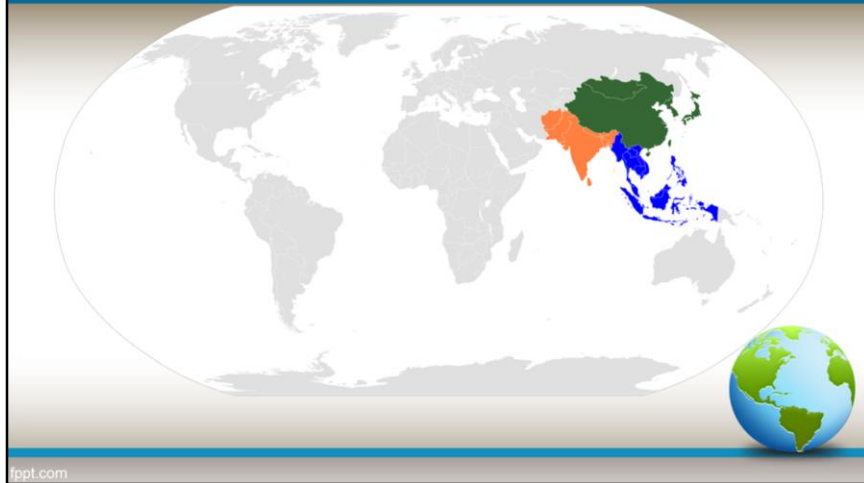
The West



“The West” refers to Western Europe and North America (or those countries populated and settled by Europeans, such as Australia, and to a lesser extent Latin America). These places are linked together economically, culturally, and politically. “Western Culture” is the culture in which you live. It is ever-changing. Think of clothing and hair styles – they change year to year. There is an abundance of consumer products because of readily available mass-produced goods that are inexpensive to buy for the middle class. TV and Radio media create new trends that spread out from their hearths (place of origin) in the large cities of New York City, Los Angeles, Chicago, Nashville (country music), and others.

“The West” has a political connotation to it as well, as the Communist leaders of the Soviet Union spurned or outright banned any influence (goods or ideas) from “The West”.

The East



“The East” or “The Eastern World” refer to countries in the Eastern Hemisphere. Like the West, they share common historical, political, cultural, and economic ties. You may have heard the term “Eastern Medicine” or “Eastern Philosophies” (religions). These phrases reference this world region. Eastern Medicine includes ancient medicinal approaches to treating patients such as various forms of herbal medicine, acupuncture, cupping therapy, gua sha, massage, exercise, and dietary therapy (compared to Western Medicine which is based more on doctors and the use of pharmaceuticals for treatment). Today, “East” and “West” influence each other, as Western medicine has adopted some approaches to treating patients from Eastern practices, and the Western approach to medicine is spreading to the Eastern world. An example would be a patient being treated for cancer using chemotherapy and/or radiation to slow the growth of the tumors while using acupuncture and herbal remedies to help offset the side effects of the chemo.

The Islamic Realm



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Also known as the Islamic World or the Muslim World. This is the region where the majority of the people are followers of the Islamic religion. Notice it stretches out beyond Southeast Asia/North Africa to include most of South Asia (large percentage of Indians are Muslim, though Hindu is the majority religion in most of the country), Central Asia, and Indonesia (the most populous Muslim country).

The Global North



These countries are more economically developed (MDCs) as they industrialized first and procured their resources from their own land or their colonies. These countries are often referred to as “Core” industrial countries

The Global South



The Global South refers to the countries that are currently experiencing an industrial boom (NICs) and the LDCs. Many of the countries in the Global South were colonial holdings for the core countries and supplied the raw materials needed for manufacturing in the North. Today, the darker blue of the shaded countries are considered to be “developing” and are coming into their own right as producers and manufacturers. There are unique challenges faced by these countries as they meet the demands for mass produced inexpensive consumer goods – rapid urbanization (rapidly growing cities) and overpopulation, high levels of poverty, high levels of pollution, and increased need for resources themselves.